provide Poland with extra economic aid, designed to help prop-up the shaky regime in Warsaw. Inevitably, the move caused hardships for other Socialist states, including the GDR.

Dear Erich!

After discussing the matter in the Politburo we decided to write to you and Comrades G. Husak, J. Kadar and T. Zhivkov with regard to an important, even extraordinary, matter. Recently, as you well know, we received Cdes. S. Kania and J. Pitikowski in Moscow. The situation in their country is extremely difficult. An acute need arises for all of us to help Poland survive the current crisis. You know very well the political situation in the PPR [Poland]. Counter-revolution is advancing and practically grabbing at the party's throat. At a recent meeting with Polish friends, we shared our considerations about the need to break the tide of events and to launch our own offensive against the forces of counterrevolution. We will inform you further about this meeting. In these conditions the situation in the economy acquires immense importance, and now it is near catastrophic.

Further aggravation of the situation in Poland threatens to inflict grave damage on the entire socialist commonwealth. Therefore, it is our internationalist, I would say our class, duty to do everything in our power not to allow this to happen. I would say right away that we are assuming the main burden in this matter. In spite of our own economic problems, which I have reported to you, we judged it necessary to provide considerable financial and economic assistance to Poland by way of giving resources in freely convertible currency and by way of additional supplies of a number of goods and products.

But one cannot avoid certain contributions from other fraternal countries. When we weighed and discussed this issue, we, of course, understood well that it was not a simple matter. Therefore, we wanted to come up with a solution that would minimally affect the fulfilment of your internal plans, one that you would be able to shoulder. Specifically, we suggest cutting back somewhat on oil supplies to a number of the countries of the socialist commonwealth, the idea being to sell this oil on the capitalist market and to